



BEFORE

After the defeat of General McClellan's Army of the Potomac in the Seven Days Battles, President Lincoln launched a new Union offensive in northern Virginia.

THE UNION ARMY OF VIRGINIA

While the [Seven Days Battles](#), were being fought in late June 1862, a **Union Army of Virginia** was formed. General John Pope, a commander with a **reputation for aggression**, was recalled from the Western Theater to **lead the new force** southward from Washington. In late July, McClellan was ordered to bring his army back from the Peninsula to **defend Washington** and reinforce Pope's army.

CONFEDERATE ACTIVITY

Confederate General Robert E. Lee rested and reorganized his **Army of Northern Virginia**, dividing it into two corps under [Stonewall Jackson](#) and [James Longstreet](#). Lee warily watched McClellan's army, camped **within striking distance** of Richmond, but dispatched Jackson to disrupt Pope's invasion of northern Virginia. On seeing that McClellan was to remain inactive, Lee contemplated **an offensive of his own**.

The campaign opened in mid-July 1862, with General Stonewall Jackson's advance to the railroad junction at Gordonsville, northwest of Richmond, which was threatened by the advance of General John Pope's Union Army of Virginia. Reinforced by a division under General A. P. Hill, Jackson set out to strike the center of the Union army, hoping to gain the upper hand by rapid maneuver.

Lee's audacious offensive

On August 9, Jackson's troops encountered Union forces under Major General Nathaniel Banks in a strong defensive position on a ridge near Cedar Mountain. The battle began with much of the Confederate column still marching well to the rear. A Union counterattack put some of Jackson's army to flight, but he rallied his troops in person and, aided by Hill's division, the Confederates carried the day. The blow was far from decisive, however, and the approach of stronger Union forces saw Jackson withdraw back to Gordonsville.

By mid-August, Lee had correctly assessed the strategic situation. Despite General George McClellan's reluctance to support his rival, General Pope, the Army of the Potomac was being withdrawn from